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The Now-Wow-How Matrix

1. Introduction

The *How-Now-Wow matrix* is a structured design methodology used to evaluate and categorize ideas based on two primary criteria: *originality* and *feasibility*. This matrix offers a systematic way to sort through creative ideas, making it easier to identify which concepts are worth pursuing. It is particularly useful during the initial stages of design and problem-solving processes, where many potential solutions are generated and need to be assessed effectively. The *HNW matrix* simplifies the decision-making process by providing a visual and conceptual framework to organize ideas into three categories:

- ***Now***: ideas that are conventional, straightforward, and immediately feasible. These solutions are practical and can be implemented with minimal risk or adjustment.
- ***Wow***: creative ideas that are also feasible. These concepts stand out due to their originality but can still be implemented without significant obstacles.
- ***How***: innovative and original ideas that pose challenges to implementation. These solutions may require further refinement, research, or resources to become practical.



Figure 1 – How-Wow-Now Flow

It has its perks in the context of innovation management as well, helping to align creative efforts with business or project goals. It ensures that the most promising ideas are identified and pursued while less practical ideas are either refined or set aside. This report will introduce the method and the many contexts to which it can be applied.

2. Background literature

The *HNW matrix* draws upon established methodologies in creativity, design thinking, and innovation management. It was developed as an evolution of earlier frameworks that sought to balance creativity with feasibility, ensuring that ideation processes remained productive and actionable.

Developed from the **CODC Matrix**[1], designed to evaluate concepts based on creativity, the *HNW matrix* implements within its structure the design thinking principles, structuring the creativity flows

[1] How-Now-Wow Matrix – Gamestorming

while ensuring feasibility of the proposed solutions. The CODC laid the groundwork by categorizing ideas and providing a structure to assess their potential. The implementation of the *HNW matrix* builds on other approaches, such as the *Future Workshop Model*, proposed by Kensing & Madsen (1991). It is structured around three phases: *critique*, *fantasy*, and *implementation*, used as base for the appearance of the HNW model.[2]

Another critical influence was given by Ulrich & Eppinger (2008) frameworks for product development. In the field of product design, the authors contributed a systematic approach to product development that aligns well with the matrix's goals. Their frameworks for evaluating design feasibility and innovation have informed the way ideas are sorted and prioritized in the *HNW matrix*.[3]

3. Structure and components

The *core components* of the *HNW matrix* consist of three primary categories[4]:

- **Now**
    - Definition: ideas that are straightforward, conventional, and immediately feasible.
    - Characteristics: these ideas often involve known solutions or minor improvements to existing practices. They are low-risk and can be quickly implemented.
    - Use case: ideal for situations where immediate action is required, or resources are limited.
- **Wow**
    - Definition: ideas that are creative, innovative, and feasible.
    - Characteristics: these solutions are original and exciting but do not require extensive changes or resources to implement. They balance novelty with practicality.
    - Use case: best suited for projects aiming to make a significant impact without excessive risk or effort.
- **How**
    - Definition: ideas that are innovative but challenging to implement.
    - Characteristics: these solutions are highly creative but may face obstacles such as technological limitations, resource constraints, or lack of immediate feasibility.

[2] A_deep_dive_into_creative_thinking_The_n.pdf
[3] A_deep_dive_into_creative_thinking_The_n.pdf

[4] Blog | Now-How-Wow Matrix | Tarlunt Consulting Group

- Use case: these ideas require further development, research, or refinement to become viable.

3.1 Benefits

- **Flexibility** and **adaptability**. The two core characteristics of the HWN matrix allow teams to support both a divergent approach and a convergent one, as well as to adapt the structured matrix to various contexts.
    - *Product development*: identifying which product features are ready to launch and which need further prototyping.
    - *Marketing strategies*: deciding on campaigns that balance creativity and feasibility.
    - *Problem-solving*: filtering through potential solutions to complex challenges.
- The **clear structure** of the How-Now-Wow Matrix ensures that the flow of ideas remains organized and productive, and helps teams avoid the common pitfalls of disorganized ideation sessions. Creativity is allowed, yet balanced with practical evaluation.
- **Efficiency**, as teams can quickly identify actionable solutions.
- **Collaboration**, encouraging team involvement and democratic decision-making.

4. Application

The *How-Now-Wow Matrix* systematically acts on three levels[5]:

- **Idea generation**;
- **Categorization**;
- **Prioritization**.

A. **Idea generation** starts through ideations method, when teams begin thinking about solutions related to a specific problem or goal. At this stage, creativity is encouraged, and no idea should be dismissed. Simple techniques such as *mind mapping* or *post-it note clustering* can be used to capture a wide range of ideas.

B. **Categorization** begins once ideas have been generated. Solutions are evaluated and sorted into the *now*, *wow*, and *how* categories. This step involves assessing each idea based on:

1. **Originality**: *How unique or novel is the idea?*
2. **Feasibility**: *Can the idea be implemented with current resources and constraints?*

[5] A_deep_dive_into_creative_thinking_The_n.pdf

C. **Prioritization** process is about reviewing the ideas within each category to determine which ones to pursue. This involves identifying:

   - *Immediate actions* (*now* and *wow* ideas).
   - *Ideas for further development* (*how* solutions).

   The goal is to prioritize solutions that offer **the most impact with the least effort**, while also setting aside time to explore innovative ideas that need refinement.

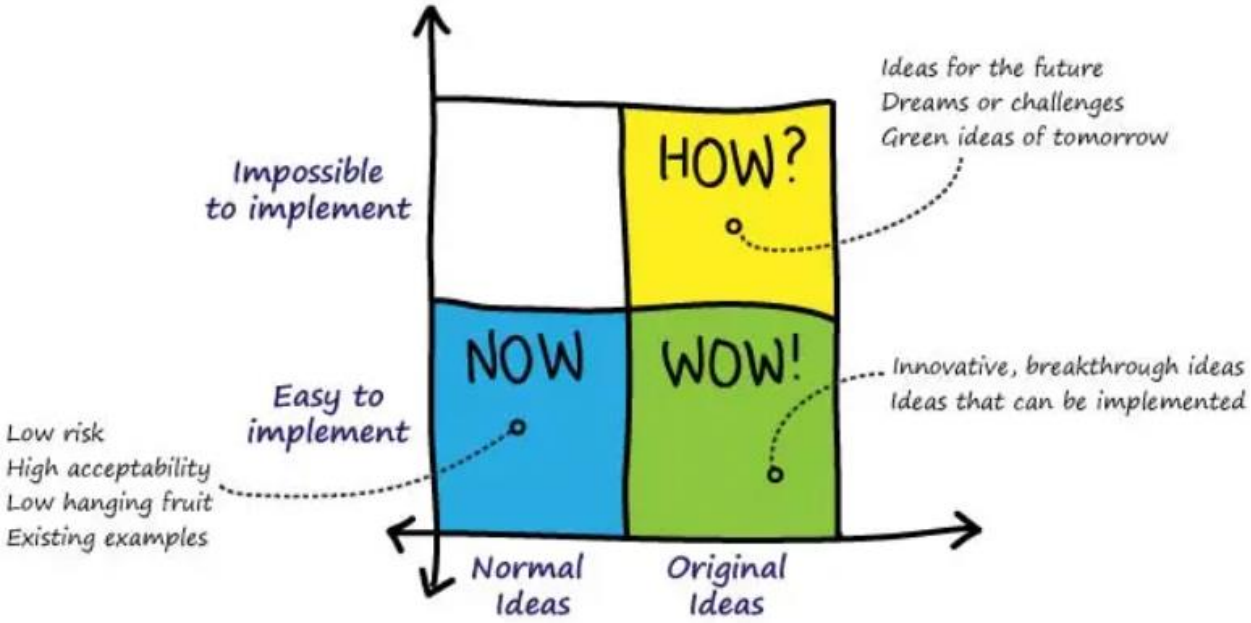


Figure 2 – How-Wow-Now Matrix

Based on the most popular "gamified" application of the matrix, visualized in *Figure 2*, implementing the *How-Now-Wow matrix* typically follows these steps[6], regardless of any context.

1. *Define the objective*: clearly state the problem, goal, or challenge to guide brainstorming. In the context of problem-solving, this phase is about clearly articulating the challenge to be addressed.

2. *Generate ideas*: use brainstorming techniques like mind mapping, group discussions, or rapid ideation of a wide range of potential solutions.

3. *Categorize ideas*: place ideas into the appropriate categories:

   a. **Now/Blue ideas**: practical, immediate solutions.

   b. **Wow/Green ideas**: creative solutions that can be implemented with minimal obstacles.

[6] How to Brainstorm Ideas With the How Now Wow Method

c. **How/Yellow ideas**: innovative but challenging solutions.[7]

4. *Evaluate and prioritize*: identify which ideas to act on immediately and which to refine for future implementation.

4.1. Variants

There are several versions of the matrix, developed based on different contexts of application.

- **The How-Now-Wow-Ciao Matrix[8]**

Enables the immediate discard option for immediately unfeasible and not worth pursuing ideas. By adding the "ciao" component, you ensure during the process that a category of ideas is already gone.

- **The How-Now-Wow-Huh?-Ciao Matrix[9]**

The team implemented a change in the first variant by adding a "huh?" category for ideas that seem unclear during the evaluation or need further exploration before a final decision to completely discard it.

- **The "Impact-Effort" matrix[10]**

This is not a proper variant of the HWN matrix, but they are often to be found together. The 2x2 matrix simply evaluates ideas based on their potential impact and the eventual effort required when implementing the solutions.

5. Quantitative improvements

Qualitative suggestions for the proposed *HNW matrix* could fix some problems in understanding or speeding up the categorization mechanisms.

- Incorporating **visual aids** or **colourful coding** could help in clarifying the categorization process and improve the speed.

- Adding a **feedback mechanism** during the reasoning could be a necessary step to ensure valuable ideas emerge in a non-judgmental, democratic environment.

Quantitative suggestions to clarify the outputs could be:

- **Scoring systems** to break down feasibility criteria into measurable classes to rank ideas objectively.

[7] How-Now-Wow matrix - Project Design Toolkit
[8] How|Now|Wow (Ciao!). Design is a team sport. Collaboration… | by Joelle Hagen | Medium
[9] Now/how/wow matrix | Impact At The Core | Erasmus University Rotterdam
[10] Impact Effort Matrix | ASQ

6. Personal reflection

Reflecting on my personal experience using the variant *How-Now-Wow-Huh?-Ciao matrix*, I've found it to be a very dynamic, fun, powerful tool for efficiently guiding the brainstorming process of solution generation. It helped the team in providing a structured yet flexible map of ideas, through which we could navigate while focusing on finding the most practical ones. Initially, the three-category *HWN system* felt restrictive due to the large number of ideas generated during our sessions. By expanding to five categories, we managed to sort ideas more effectively, ensuring that only feasible and promising solutions were selected. The most satisfying aspect was witnessing abstract concepts evolve into concrete, actionable steps that met the specific needs of our users. However, flexibility is crucial — the matrix isn't a universal solution. It works best when adapted to the team's dynamics and project goals. The framework fosters a creative environment while keeping practicality in check, making the balancing act between creativity and feasibility much easier.

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